one month. The CM, say insiders, consulted senior party leaders and officials before deciding not to take any action against Kumar till the inquiry was over. The ADGP, it is learnt, in fact, had met the CM and requested him to investigate the MLA's allegations.

Talking to INDIA TODAY, Kumar said he would cooperate with the investigation. "I have served the government in my 29-year-long service with dignity.... The allegations are false," he added. A 1995-batch Indian Police Service (IPS) officer, Kumar has held important posts in both the LDF and Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) regimes and was given charge of law & order in 2022. Seen as the blue-eyed boy of both Pinarayi and P. Sasi, he was recently directed by the CM to monitor the rescue operations after the landslides in Wayanad on July 30 and also briefed Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his visit.

The cracks show up

Despite Pinarayi's assurances, political headwinds against him are gaining speed. The Congress on September 2 organised statewide protests to demand his resignation. "CM Pinarayi Vijayan and his office stand exposed," said leader of Opposition V.D. Satheesan. "Earlier, his principal secretary was involved in a gold smuggling case. Now his key police officer has been exposed.... What explanation can the CM offer? He must go."

The latest row has also exposed fissures within both the police department and the ruling coalition, with a "powerful lobby" including CPI(M) members and senior police officers alleged to be covertly supporting Anvar's campaign. The MLA has denied this. Sources suggest that Kumar and DGP Darvesh Saheb have long been at odds, with the latter even approaching P. Sasi with grievances against his subordinate, who he feels has emerged as a "supercop" with the CMO's backing. Once promoted to the DGP's post out of turn, say insiders, Darvesh Saheb has now fallen out of favour.

There seems to be very little love lost between a section of LDF leaders and P. Sasi as well. After Anvar, Karat Razack, a former Independent MLA who, too, had the CPI(M)'s backing, has come forward to allege that even ruling party legislators don't have access to the CMO ever since Sasi became political secretary. Adding to Pinarayi's woes, his own party MLA and former minister K.T. Jaleel has announced that he will soon launch a website to expose all corrupt officials in the present regime. Curiously, the allegations have surfaced amid senior CPI(M) leader E.P. Jayarajan's unceremonious removal from the post of LDF convenor.



"The CM and his office stand exposed. Earlier [in 2020], his principal secretary M. Sivasankar was involved in the diplomatic channel gold smuggling case. Now, his key police officer has been exposed. What explanation can the CM offer? He must go"

V.D. SATHEESAN
Leader of Opposition

A history of controversies

Pinarayi has so far not said a word on the allegations made against P. Sasi, who has maintained his innocence in whatever interactions he has had with the local media. An old warhorse of the party, Sasi had earlier served as political secretary to former CM E.K. Nayanar (1996-2001). Back then, he had faced allegations of shielding Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leader P.K. Kunhalikutty in the infamous ice cream parlour sex case. Several politicians and other VIPs were named in the 1997 scandal that involved sexual exploitation of girls at an ice cream parlour being run as a brothel in Kozhikode.

Later, during his term as Kannur district secretary in 2010, Sasi himself faced sexual abuse charges from a Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) woman leader. Based on her complaint, the CPI(M) had demoted him before expelling him from the party in 2011. It was only in 2019 that Sasi was included in the party's State Committee and Secretariat. Three years later, the CM brought him on board as his political secretary. Ever since, Sasi has only grown in influence, especially with the home department, and thus the police force, under his virtual charge.

But the main accuser in this case has his own fair share of controversies too. A businessman-turned-politician, Anvar belongs to a prominent family historically associated with the Congress. Representing Nilambur constituency as an Independent candidate since 2016, he has often found himself on the wrong side of the law due to his commercial activities—land encroachments, unauthorised constructions et al. The CPI(M) chose to look the other way as Anvar's clout helped it widen its base in the IUML-dominated Malappuram district. But his ambitions of getting a ministerial berth, say sources, were never fulfilled. Now, as it turns out, he has put Pinarayi in a precarious position.

After firing salvos for four straight days, Anvar announced a ceasefire of sorts after meeting Pinarayi on September 3. During the meeting, which lasted for half an hour, Anvar submitted in writing all his allegations against Kumar and P. Sasi though both have denied any wrongdoing. Later, addressing the media, Anvar said the CM had given him a patient hearing and the assurance that "appropriate action" would be taken. For now, Anvar may have chosen to take a calculated retreat, but the deluge is far from over for the Pinarayi government. ■